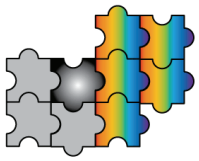
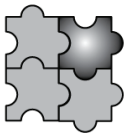
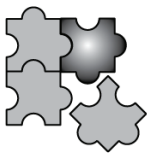
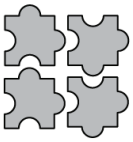
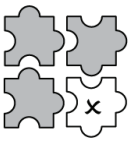
Guideline to Grading Written Assignments

Reflective journals and the term paper are scored according to
I. Higher level thinking (6 points),
II. Understanding of the text(s) (4 points),
III. Language (2 points) and
IV. Format (1 point for reflective journals and 2 points for the term paper).

I. Higher level thinking (6 points)

Argumentation is a dimension concerned with reasoning powers. The following table explains various levels of thinking with an example.

Points	**Description**		
	Accuracy	**Understanding of the problem**	**Coherence**
6: Outstanding (Unanticipated and successful extension) 	Same as 5.	On top of 5: - See the problem in a **broader** perspective. - Use of high level abstract thinking to **generalize** to other contexts.	On top of 5: Usually conclusion held **open** or **qualified** to allow logically possible alternatives.
5: Strong (Logically related points) 	All points/arguments are - **correct.** - appropriately **elaborated**. - appropriately **evidenced**.	Includes - **all** relevant **aspects**. - their **interrelations**. - **reflection** (see note †).	- With **coherence** to form a whole picture. - The whole picture supports a **firm conclusion**.
4: Good (Well evidenced points) 	Same as 5.	Not as good as 5: Some **missing** interrelation.	Not as good as 5: - A **weakly supported conclusion** as a result of missing interrelations, - even if there is unanticipated and successful extension. 

3. Fair (Presence of mistakes, missing evidence or no reflection) 	Some points/arguments are - **incorrect**, or - **lack of elaboration**, or - stated **without necessary evidence**. 	- **Invalid** or **missing** interrelations due to mistakes. - **Superficial**, **far-fetched** reflection or **no reflection** even there is no missing interrelation. 	A **weakly supported** or **no conclusion** due to mistakes, missing interrelations or missing reflection.
2: Acceptable (No interrelation) 	Includes **several** relevant points or even mistakes. 	**Fails** to see interrelations.	A **weakly supported** or **no conclusion** due to mistakes or missing interrelations.
1: Limited (Single point) 	- An answer based on only **one** relevant aspect, or - The points are **stated without elaboration**. 	**No interrelation** can be found.	Conclusion is **limited** and likely to be dogmatic.
0: Seriously flawed (Missing the Point	- **Avoid** the question, or - Repeat the question.	—	—

†: Reflection is your personal view or evaluation in **one or more** of the following aspects: 1. achievement and limitations of scientific methods, 2. impacts on how human beings view life and physical world, 3. societal implications and 4. implications on contemporary human conditions.

II. Understanding of the texts (4 points)

Understanding of texts adds to reasoning power. It can be reflected in citations and comments on the texts. The following table illustrates various levels of understanding with examples about Plato's "Allegory of the Cave".

Points, descriptions and examples
4: Very good (show good understanding and have insight into the text)
e.g.1: Seeking the truth, which is usually hidden behind complex phenomena, is just like escaping from the cave. On the wall are the shadows of the puppets. If physical phenomena are just shadows, it makes sense for scientists to explain Nature with laws. [Analysis: "Seeking … puppets" summarizes the text. "If physical … with laws" properly extends the theme of the text to natural science.]
e.g.2: Outside the cave is the shining truth: this sounds like faith. If those who have seen the outside world are educated, are those who attempted but could not escape are just the same as those fettered prisoners? Seeking the truth but finding nothing is common indeed. [Analysis: The mentioned keywords "outside the cave", "shining truth", "educated" and "fettered prisoners"

demonstrated the reader's understanding. Student is able to apply the case to "those who attempted but could not escape", which is an extension of idea. The closing "Seeking the truth but finding nothing is common" is questioning the author's idea on the process of truth seeking, and such question shows the reader's unique insight.] 例一：真理往往藏於複雜表象的背後，發掘真理有如走出洞穴。皮影匠人弄影是牆上皮影的根本緣由，如果物理表象也如同皮影，這讓我明白到何以科學家總想以定律解釋自然。 〔分析：「真……緣由」綜合文章重點。「如果……自然」把文章內容正確地延伸至自然科學。〕 例二：洞外世界是光明的真理，這有點信仰的味道。若果說見過外面就是受了教育，那些嘗試出去而沒有成功的人是不是就只等如被鎖的囚徒？尋找真理最後沒有得著才是常情吧！ 〔分析：「洞外世界」、「光明」、「教育」、「被鎖的囚徒」都是重點，顯示同學了解文章。同學把文章應用到「嘗試出去而沒有成功」的人身上，這是討論的伸延，最後以「尋找真理最後沒有得著才是常情吧！」作結，質疑文章所述那走出洞穴，並理所當然地看到真相的過程，這質疑正表現了同學對文章的洞悉。〕
3: Good (showed some understanding of the text)
e.g.1: Humans are fettered by the limitations of perception. Seeking the truth, which is usually hidden behind complex phenomena, is just like escaping from the cave. [Analysis: Keywords "fettered", "escaping from the cave" and "light" are mentioned, which shows the reader caught the points. The reader further points out that the fetter is like the "limitations of perception", and the escape from the cave is like the seeking of truth, which shows his/her digestion of the text.] e.g.2: Those who are back to the cave no longer occupy themselves with human affairs, but why are the shadows not important? It takes time to study them! Is it not more desirable to remain in the cave and enjoy the recognition and admiration from others? [Analysis: e.g.2: Reader catches the idea of the text with his/her generalization in the first sentence, and pieces like "shadows", "recognition" and "admiration" are mentioned. The two questions show the reader's digestion of the text with clear standpoints, but no extension is made.] 例一：人類有感官的限制，有如上鎖的囚徒；真理往往藏於看似複雜的表象背後，發掘真理的過程有如走出洞穴。 〔分析：同學懂得使用「上鎖的囚徒」、「走出洞穴」、「光明」等詞語，表示他了解文章重點。他指出比喻中的鎖是感官的限制，走出洞穴是指發掘真理的過程，這表示同學能消化文章內容。〕 例二：返回洞穴的人，看破人間虛榮，但難道皮影的先後就不值得研究麼？眼睛也得疲勞啊！留在洞內研究之餘，還可以得到大家認同和獎勵，不是更好嗎？ 〔分析：同學能了解文章內容，因此能簡潔地以「返回洞人的人，看破人間虛榮」來總結故事，並指出「皮影的先後」、「認同」、「獎勵」這些細節。分享中的兩個反問顯示同學能消化內容，也能提出自己的立場，但未有將討論延伸。〕
2: Fair (Read the text, showed some understandings of the text. Copy and paste some keywords from the text to form a summary, with no digestion.)
e.g.1: "Cave", "prisoners", "shadows", "the sun", "honour" and "pain" have their counterparts in the real world. [Analysis: Proper keywords listed without digestion, and jumping to comment without reason. Comment with almost no elaboration and support.] e.g.2: The world outside the cave is not necessarily a perfect one. The cave can also be a warm place to stay. [Analysis: Reader shows partial understanding of the text. The setting of the allegory is not bounded by the

outside or the inside of the cave. The meaning of "warm place" is unclear. Is it the warm from the peer admiration or his/her acquaintance to the environment?]

例一：洞穴、囚徒、皮影、太陽、獎勵、刺痛，都在現實世界得到一一對應。

〔分析：「洞穴」、「囚徒」、「皮影」、「太陽」、「獎勵」、「刺痛」固然都是文章的鑰詞，但同學未能顯示他已消化文章內容。「都在現實世界得到一一對應」這評論出現得太突然，同學未提供任何理由，便立刻作這結論。〕

例二：我不同意洞穴外就一定是美好世界，洞內其實可以很溫暖。

〔分析：從「洞穴外」、「洞內」這些詞語可看出同學的確讀過文章，但只有片面了解，因爲文章並非只有洞的內外，還有囚徒走出與返回的過程。此外，「溫暖」一詞意義未明。它是指獲得同儕認同而得的溫暖，還是因留在熟識環境而有的安全感？〕

1: Poor (Superficial sharing, Pretended reading the text.
Misunderstanding of core content of text)

e.g.1: The Platonic philosophy is unprecedented. It has made great contribution to the human civilization. It is the root of philosophy. It denies the anti-intellectualism.

[Analysis: Irrelevant point with the text. Too superficial comment which is hardly to be reader's original idea.]

e.g.2: The cave is just like a shelter which gives protection to travelers. It is indeed a precious moment to find Plato, who was a rational philosopher, to be such a sentimental person.

[Analysis: Although the "cave" is from the text, the interpretation is totally irrelevant from the text. Weak understanding.]

例一：柏拉圖思想貢獻重大、前無古人，開啓哲學，否定了知識無用論。

〔分析：與文章內容毫無關係，是缺乏理論之抒情，是人云亦云之作。〕

例二：洞穴好像雨中的避風港，讓在外面流蕩的遊子得到庇護。柏拉圖作爲哲學家，能如此感性實屬難得。

〔分析：洞穴一詞雖然與文章有關，但同學完全誤解文章，對洞穴一詞的了解極爲片面。〕

III. Language (2 points)

The language used in writing should be accurate in terms of its grammar and word choice. The writing should also be concise and succinct. The table below illustrates different levels of language accuracy and succinctness.

Points		Description	Example and analysis
2	Strong	- Generally **fluent** and **clear**. - Basically free from errors in grammar and word usage.	e.g. 1: In most metals, the charge carriers, which conduct electric current, are mainly conduction electrons. e.g. 2: In most metals, the current carriers are mainly conduction electrons. [Analysis: No error. Succinct.]
1.5	Fair	- **Inadequate** in fluency and clarity. - **Some errors** in grammar and word usage.	e.g.: In most kind of metal, the charge carriers conduct electric current, are mainly conduction electrons. [Analysis: Errors in kind(s) and metal(s). "are" lacks a subject.]
1	Seriously flawed	- A **lack** of fluency and clarity. - **Riddled** with errors in grammar and word usage.	e.g.: In many metal, the charged takers will move an electric flow. They called electrons. [Analysis: The choices of words "takers", "move" and "flow" is incorrect. "metal" should be plural. Passive voice should be used for "called".]

0	Fundamentally deficient	- There are **so many** errors that they form a series of **obstacles** to the reader's comprehension.	e.g.: In metals, electric particles is a charged flow. Electron is their name. [Analysis: Incomprehensible.]

IV. Format (1 point/2 points)

Good academic writing should illustrate a standard rhetorical structure and clear, accurate use of citations. 0, 0.5 or 1 point will be given for each of these two aspects.

Structure: There should be a clear introduction, supporting paragraphs in the body of the paper and a conclusion. The following webpage (by Independent Learning Centre) provides very useful guidance on this:
http://www.ilc.cuhk.edu.hk/chinese/AWOnline/structure.html (in Chinese)

Citations: There should be footnotes/endnotes where appropriate. A list of references or bibliography should be available.

Points	Citations	Structure
1	There are clear and accurate citations wherever necessary.	A standard rhetorical structure is found. The coherence in structure facilitates the reader's comprehension.
0.5	Some citations are incomplete or inaccurate.	There is some degree of deviation from the standard rhetorical structure. The coherence of structure is inadequate.
0	No citations found.	The structure is simply confusing.

Here is the score allocation:

	Citations	Structure
Reflective journal	1	Not required
Term paper	1	1

- End -